

Merchant Taylors' Company of London: Apprentices 1583–1800

The data provides an index of the surviving records of apprenticeship bindings in the Merchant Taylors' Company up to 1800. The data has been gathered from the archive of the company in the Guildhall Library. The principal manuscript source in the collection used for the construction of this index is the series of 'binding books' that begin in 1583.

Ms 34038/1 1583–1593

Ms 34038/2 1593–1597

Ms 34038/3 1598–1602

Ms 34038/4 1603–1605

Ms 34038/5 1606–1609

Ms 34038/6 1609–1612

Ms 34038/7 1613–1616

Ms 34038/8 1617–1622

Ms 34038/9 1623–1628

Ms 34038/10 1629–1635

Ms 34038/11 1635–1639

Ms 34038/12 1639–1646

Ms 34038/13 1647–1654

Ms 34038/14 1654–1658

Ms 34038/15 1658–1669

Ms 34038/16 1669–1680

Ms 34038/17 1680–1696

Ms 34038/18 1696–1718

Ms 34038/19 1718–1761

Ms 34038/20 1762–1819

Entries in these manuscripts typically give the name and trade or status of the apprentice's father, his parish, the name of the master and the term of apprenticeship. The residence of the master is also usually given and (particularly from the mid-seventeenth century) the trade in which the apprentice was being trained is often stated. All of this information has been extracted up to 1800. Additionally, ad hoc supplementary information given in the apprenticeship records about the master or apprentice has also been included; for example,

some apprenticeship records note that the master is a merchant or identify his trading company membership.

The index has been supplemented in two main ways. After registering their details, the apprentice would attend the 'Ordinary Court' to be formally bound with his or her master. Minute books of the proceedings in this court, which dealt with matters relating to company membership, include name lists of masters and apprentices being bound. While they do not provide additional detail about the master or apprentice, these lists have been used to check name spellings. Notably, some apprentices do not proceed with the binding despite their details being registered in Ms 34038. Secondly, the index uses information found in the minutes of ordinary court proceedings concerning the later careers of apprentices, in particular, the records viii Introduction of turnings over to new masters, apprentices becoming free of the company and details of disputes between apprentices and their masters. Details from these minutes have been used to fill in or correct details in the index. In some cases, the minutes give the full record of an apprenticeship binding that had not been recorded in the main register. For example, if an apprentice had been improperly bound (with a scrivener, for instance, rather than through the appropriate company process) but had nevertheless served a full term with a freeman of the company, he could appeal to the court for his freedom giving evidence of his record of service. The index has been supplemented with these entries. A small number of these cases identify a binding that predates 1583.

The series MS 34038 is ostensibly complete, with a systematic record of the details of apprentices beginning in December 1586. Prior to that, the entries take the form of rough notes, have gaps, and are sketchier in the details they provide. Earlier bindings can be traced through the Wardens' account books (Ms 34048) but these contain only the names of masters and apprentices and have not been included in this index. Early court minutes have been published by Matthew Davies *The Merchant Taylors' Company of London: court minutes 1486–1493* (Stamford: Richard III and Yorkist History Trust in association with Paul Watkins, 2000). Matthew Davies and Ann Saunders *The History of the Merchant Taylors' Company* (Leeds: Maney, 2004) provides a history of the company that includes details of court procedures.

Indexing and editorial procedures follow similar methods to those employed in *Apprenticeship Disputes in the Lord Mayor's Court of London 1573–1723*. Readers should note that old style date references have not been modernised.

Work on the database was conducted over several years. For the UK Data Archive, additional research has been added that was done in the course of making the principal index. This includes notes on the freedoms of apprentices found in the company registers. More details of this supplementary data is given in the main Excel spreadsheet.

Queries about the data should be directed towards the database creator Michael Scott (The University of Manchester).

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EXCEL DOC GUIDE

COMB provides the core data used for 'The Merchant Taylors Company of London: apprentices 1583-1800' by Michael Scott

<https://www.britishrecordsociety.org/publications/136-138/>

The data underwent some modest corrections and adjustment for the purposes of print publication, so there may be some very minor differences between the two outputs.

The primary sources are held by the Guildhall Library Manuscripts Section.

The arrangement of the data should be self-explanatory, beginning with references to the binding book volumes and page numbers, details of apprentices and their families, masters and their locations, dates of binding, and subsequent turnings over.

Some additional datasets not used for the hardcopy publication are included here:

Court App:

These are names of apprentices presented by their masters for binding identified in the court minute books (the ordinary court minutes MS34017 or draft minutes MS34018 or, for earlier entries the main court minutes series MS34010) but without corresponding information in the binding books.

Redemptions:

The court date is on the left hand side (see the court minute books for source material) and the Court of Aldermen order date is on the right hand side. If you are searching for an individual admitted by redemption, there may be more information in the Court of Aldermen repertories (held at the London Metropolitan Archives).

Patrimonies:

The court date entries (see court minute books) are on the left followed by the names (with fathers) and further details. Some entries also identify the people presenting the candidate for patrimony -- these are given in columns on the right hand side.

Freedoms:

This worksheet follows a similar outline to the main 'COMB' worksheet but includes data on freedoms (along with the individuals presenting evidence in support of the apprentice's service).

For considerations of space and cost, this material was not included in the hardcopy publication. As such, it has not gone through the same degree of checking and correction as the binding data, and includes some editing queries and notes that have not been resolved.

Despite the draft status, the freedom data is included here for the interest and use of researchers as it provides a very large body of useful supplementary information about apprenticeship outcomes, trades and locations.

Further enquiries may be sent to Michael Scott:

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